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Effective coping strategies for stressed frontline employees in service occupations: outcomes and drivers

服务行业压力前线员工的有效应对策略：结果和驱动因素

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ABSTRACT

Despite extensive research on the negative outcomes of role ambiguity in boundary-spanning positions, insight into how to prevent frontline employees from experiencing role ambiguity is sparse. This study addresses questions as to how the problem-focused coping strategies used by frontline employees can effectively reduce perceived role ambiguity. The gathered evidence indicates that only *action coping* is effective, whereas *instrumental support seeking* in fact enhances perceived role ambiguity. An examination of intrinsic and extrinsic coping resources as drivers of coping has revealed that *conscientiousness* and *supervisor support* are helpful coping resources. Contrastively, *neuroticism* drives insufficient coping and inhibits the effective use of coping resources. We find that managers of service firms should provide training to ensure effective supervisor support; also, in recruitment procedures they should consider potential employees' personality traits, to reduce and prevent role ambiguity experienced by frontline employees.

摘要

尽管对跨职位中角色模糊的负面影响进行了广泛的研究，对于如何防止一线员工出现角色模糊的研究却不多见。本研究探讨一线员工采用以问题为中心的应对策略如何有效减少角色模糊感。收集的证据表明，只有采取行动应对才是有效的，而寻求工具支持实际上增强了人们的角色模糊感。对作为应对驱动因素的内外外部应对资源的研究表明，责任心和主管支持是有用的应对资源。相反，神经质会导致应对能力不足，并抑制应对资源的有效利用。本研究发现服务公司的管理者应该提供培训以确保有效的主管支持；此外，在招聘程序中，公司管理者应该考虑潜在员工的个性特征，以减少和防止一线员工的角色模糊。

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关键词

角色模糊；应对方式；应对资源；个性特征；社会支持

Introduction

Customer service is increasingly important in a service-dominated world. Relatedly, frontline employees' job performance largely drives customer satisfaction, to the extent that it

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constitutes an essential success factor for service firms (Brady & Cronin, 2001; Chan & Wan, 2012; Di Mascio, 2010). Further, increasingly diversified customer demands, new technologies that mediate customer-employee contact, and the growing complexity of service firms combine to foster insecurity and ambiguity for frontline employees (Schmitz & Ganesan, 2014; Zablah, Franke, Brown, & Bartholomew, 2012). Thus, it is not surprising that boundary-spanning frontline employees' role ambiguity is still a major issue for service firms (Ambrose, Rutherford, Shepherd, & Tashchian, 2014), even if research cautions about its negative outcomes, which include decreased job satisfaction and job performance, burnout, and withdrawal (Bettencourt & Brown, 2003; Schmitz & Ganesan, 2014; Singh, 2000). Actually, service employees rank among the highest scores on job strain rankings (Eurofound and EU-OSHA, 2014).

Notwithstanding this knowledge, research into how to prevent frontline employees from experiencing role ambiguity is insufficient (Schmitz & Ganesan, 2014; Singh, 2000; Zablah et al., 2012). A small number of studies looks at several external factors, as well as at personal characteristics that reduce the perception of role ambiguity for frontline employees (e.g. Babin & Boles, 1996; Coelho, Augusto, & Lages, 2011; Teas, 1983). However, no study to date has looked at potential actions frontline employees could apply themselves to reduce emerging role ambiguity, in spite of the particular importance such findings would have. Frontline employees often work under strict conditions to meet the expectations of their employer in its efforts to compete in the marketplace (Auh, Menguc, & Jung, 2014; Chan & Wan, 2012; Yu, Patterson, & de Ruyter, 2013). The role setting implies that boundary spanners mostly solve customers' problems on their own, as direct feedback from supervisors is rarely available during immediate customer contact (Bettencourt & Brown, 2003; MacKenzie, Podsakoff, & Rich, 2001). In such an autonomous environment a frontline employee's self-applicable spectrum of available tactics is most important in managing role ambiguity.

Coping, a self-applied stress reduction method that attracts considerable attention in life, consumer, and general occupational stress research, remains under-researched in boundary-spanner service research (Boyd, Lewin, & Sager, 2009; Srivastava & Tang, 2015). Only a few extant studies examine the relation between frontline employees' role ambiguity and coping based on the model of Lazarus and Folkman (1984) that differentiates between problem-focused and emotion-focused coping (Boyd et al., 2009; Lewin & Sager, 2008; Srivastava & Tang, 2015). These studies investigate how both problem-focused and emotion-focused coping reduce stress on an overall level, and show that problem-focused coping is generally sufficient for stress reduction (Boyd et al., 2009; Lewin & Sager, 2008; Srivastava & Tang, 2015). However, recent consumer coping research has revealed that problem-focused coping follows one of two distinct coping strategies that have different effects on consumers' stress perceptions, namely action coping or instrumental support seeking (Duhachek, 2005; Strizhakova, Tsarenko, & Ruth, 2012). Similar differential effects of problem-focused coping strategies on frontline employees' role ambiguity perceptions have hitherto not been examined in service literature, nor have the coping resources that might trigger the use of either strategy.

Noting the limited results regarding boundary spanners' problem-focused coping strategies and based on Selzer (2017), we investigate which problem-focused coping strategy – action coping or instrumental support seeking (Duhachek, 2005) – most effectively reduces perceived role ambiguity among frontline employees. We also identify the resources that trigger the use of these coping strategies, determining whether intrinsic or extrinsic

coping resources (i.e. personality traits of conscientiousness and neuroticism vs. social support by supervisors or the team, respectively) promote effective coping and prevent the use of ineffective coping strategies. Our research model is depicted in [Figure 1](#).

The results of our study, based on data from 390 retail bank employees, contribute to service research and, especially, role stress and coping research in four important ways. First, we extend and distinguish between prior findings of boundary-spanner research (Boyd et al., 2009; Lewin & Sager, 2008), to show that action coping, as opposed to instrumental support seeking, is the only problem-focused coping strategy that reduces role ambiguity among frontline employees. Second, we identify conscientiousness and supervisor support as important drivers of effective action coping, which extends prior conceptual research (Goolsby, 1992; Porter, Kraft, & Claycomb, 2003) by giving concrete insight into effective coping resources. Third, we analyze interactions between personality traits and social support, and how this affects coping (Carver & Connor-Smith, 2010). In doing so, we are the first to find that neuroticism is an important disruptive factor, triggering ineffective coping and inhibiting the positive effects of supervisor support. Fourth, we show empirically that social support in a service firm has to differentiate between supervisor support and team support (Susskind, Kacmar, & Borchgrevink, 2003), as each social support type has different effects on the use of coping strategies. Supervisor support directly pushes frontline employees to resolve ambiguities autonomously, while team support is only effective as coping resource that assists supervisor support. In an additional analysis, we underline the importance of managing frontline employees' role ambiguity, as such ambiguity has a significant negative impact on customers' positive word of mouth and trust.

In the next section, we outline research on role ambiguity and coping, as well as on drivers of coping, to develop our hypotheses. We then explain the study context, sample, and measures, following which we give our study's results. Finally, we highlight both research and managerial implications, and identify directions for further research.

Research background and hypotheses development

Experiencing role ambiguity in service settings

Role ambiguity is a common phenomenon experienced by frontline employees in boundary-spanning positions (Bettencourt & Brown, 2003; Schmitz & Ganesan, 2014; Singh, 1998,

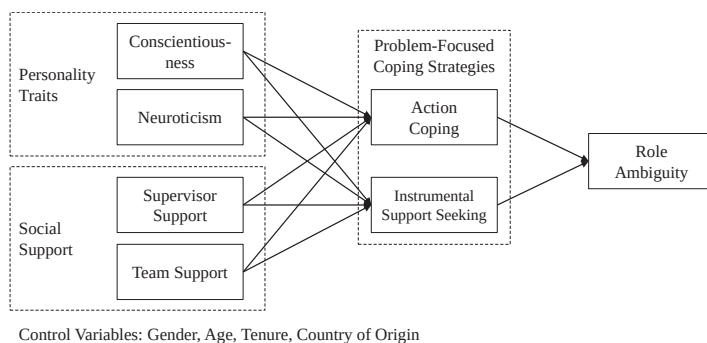


Figure 1. Research model.

2000). It is defined as a lack of clarity regarding behavioral requirements (Bettencourt & Brown, 2003; Rizzo, House, & Lirtzman, 1970), and occurs when frontline employees do not have the information they need to fulfill their roles (Bettencourt & Brown, 2003). Role ambiguity leads to negative job outcomes, such as lower job satisfaction, job performance, and organizational commitment, and a higher propensity for burnout and withdrawal (Bettencourt & Brown, 2003; Schmitz & Ganesan, 2014; Singh, 1998, 2000; Zablah et al., 2012). Thus, reducing experienced role ambiguity is important for maintaining and promoting frontline employees' job satisfaction and job performance (Bettencourt & Brown, 2003; Schmitz & Ganesan, 2014; Singh, 1998, 2000), which fosters perceived service quality, satisfaction, positive word of mouth, and customers' loyalty (Brady & Cronin, 2001; Liao & Chuang, 2004, 2007), all of which should contribute to a service firm's success.

Coping with role ambiguity

According to coping theory, cognitive or behavioral 'efforts to master conditions that tax or exceed adaptive resources' (Latack, 1986, p. 377) can reduce perceptions of stress in a dynamic process (Goolsby, 1992; Lazarus & Folkman, 1984). Despite the high relevance of coping and its effects on stress perception, pertinent research related to boundary-spanning settings is scarce and does not consider the most up-to-date results of coping research in other settings (Duhachek, 2005; Goolsby, 1992; Porter et al., 2003). Earlier research distinguishes between problem-focused and emotion-focused coping (Goolsby, 1992; Latack, 1986; Lazarus & Folkman, 1984), showing that an attempt to manipulate the environment to reduce the source of stress (problem-focused coping) differs from a reappraisal of the environment stimuli to manage the negative emotions caused by that source (emotion-focused coping; Goolsby, 1992; Latack, 1986; Lazarus & Folkman, 1984). Existing research on boundary-spanner coping generally shows sufficiency in stress reduction of overall problem-focused coping and insufficiency of emotion-focused coping (Boyd et al., 2009; Lewin & Sager, 2008). However, Duhachek (2005) argues that distinguishing only between problem-focused and emotion-focused coping is theoretically and empirically inaccurate; instead, he subdivides problem-focused coping into two different strategies, namely action coping and instrumental support seeking (Duhachek, 2005). Although first results on consumer coping indicate differential effects on stress perceptions (Duhachek, 2005; Strizhakova et al., 2012), existing service literature hitherto has not examined the two problem-focused coping strategies separately.

Action coping implies autonomously engaging in problem-solving behavior, which includes cognitive and behavioral actions targeted at solving the problem (Duhachek, 2005). Existing coping research proposes that a positive attitude toward a stressor implies that the recipient believes in successfully manipulating the environment to reduce the source of ambiguity (Boyd et al., 2009; Goolsby, 1992; Lazarus & Folkman, 1984). This positive, constructive attitude toward the stressors helps people perceive ambiguity as less severe (Goolsby, 1992; Lazarus & Folkman, 1984; Lewin & Sager, 2008). Moreover, through action coping the recipient actually eliminates uncertainties (Goolsby, 1992). In boundary-spanning settings, such a self-reliant and proactive approach should be effective. Frontline employees who actively solve problems most likely recognize their

strict working conditions (Chan & Wan, 2012) and find a solution that fits these conditions to manage the role ambiguity.

H₁: The tendency to use action coping reduces perceived role ambiguity of frontline employees.

Instrumental support seeking refers to turning to social resources in seeking solutions for faced stressors (Duhachek, 2005; Strizhakova et al., 2012). Unlike action coping though, it requires the involvement of others. The few, ambiguous studies in this realm tend to neglect single sub-dimensions of problem-focused coping; however, Carver, Scheier, and Weintraub (1989) show that instrumental support seeking differs notably from action coping. We recognize the distinction, and argue that in boundary-spanning positions, instrumental support seeking cannot reduce role ambiguity effectively. Frontline employees usually cannot or do not consult others in the first place and, thus, do not receive feedback during the actually stressful, ambiguous situation (MacKenzie et al., 2001). Moreover, the strict working conditions of frontline employees and heterogeneous customer demands (Chan & Wan, 2012) make it difficult for anyone else to help a frontline employee find solutions for specific uncertainties. Instrumental support seeking might even be damaging, in that people continue to focus on the ambiguous situation while telling others about it (Strizhakova et al., 2012). If others cannot help change the situation, such instrumental support seeking can intensify the constantly repeated, negative emotions (Strizhakova et al., 2012). Thus, instrumental support seeking might not solve frontline employees' role ambiguity perceptions, but instead can intensify feelings of insecurity.

H₂: The tendency to use instrumental support seeking enhances the perceived role ambiguity of frontline employees.

Coping resources

According to Lazarus and Folkman's (1984) transactional model of stress and coping, the choice of effective or ineffective coping strategies depends on the coping resources available to the person. Conceptual research on boundary-spanner coping already distinguishes intrinsic (personal) from extrinsic (environmental) coping resources, which could push employees to use particular coping strategies (Goolsby, 1992; Thoits, 1995). Conceptual research on coping in private contexts further highlights personality traits and social support aspects as the most important tools for coping with stress (DeLongis & Holtzman, 2005). To extend such conceptual studies, we require empirical evidence to explain how and why personality traits and social support affect boundary spanners' choices of coping strategies.

A meta-analysis of life stress coping by Connor-Smith and Flachsbart (2007) indicates that personality traits relate to certain coping strategies, especially in stressful settings (e.g. boundary-spanning occupations). Conscientiousness is most strongly related to particular problem-solving and engagement coping strategies; neuroticism, contrastively, predicts support seeking responses (Carver & Connor-Smith, 2010; Connor-Smith & Flachsbart, 2007). Accordingly, we focus on conscientiousness and neuroticism as internal coping resources in this study.

Conscientiousness encompasses personality facets such as perfectionism, diligence, organization, and prudence (Ashton & Lee, 2009). People with high levels of conscientiousness can perform boring or unpleasant tasks, because they can focus on the positive aspects of such tasks without being bothered (Connor-Smith & Flachsbart, 2007; McCrae & John, 1992). They exhibit high levels of discipline, impulse control, persistence, and achievement orientation (Carver & Connor-Smith, 2010; Connor-Smith & Flachsbart, 2007). Such capabilities to solve problems autonomously and focus on potential solutions to a problem should support the use of action coping in customer contact settings while simultaneously preventing frontline employees from seeking help from others (instrumental support seeking).

H₃: Conscientiousness (a) promotes frontline employees' tendency to use action coping and (b) lessens their tendency to use instrumental support seeking.

Neuroticism refers to aspects such as sentimentality, anxiety, and dependence (Ashton & Lee, 2009), related to negative emotionality and physiological reactivity to stress (Connor-Smith & Flachsbart, 2007; McCrae & John, 1992). Ashton and Lee (2009) assert that neuroticism entails dependency, because highly neurotic people are vulnerable to distress and tend to seek comfort from others. Highly neurotic frontline employees thus are likely to engage in instrumental support seeking, and their negative emotionality could distract them from autonomously solving problems.

H₄: Neuroticism (a) lessens frontline employees' tendency to use action coping and (b) promotes their tendency to use instrumental support seeking.

According to Thoits' (1995) conceptual view, perception of social support is another important determinant of coping strategies. DeLongis and Holtzman (2005) assert that the perception of being socially supported is crucial for coping with life stress. However, these conceptual findings cannot specify the impact of social support on action coping and instrumental support seeking. Nor is it clear whether social support should come in the form of supervisor support or of team support from colleagues (Liaw, Chi, & Chuang, 2010; Susskind et al., 2003). The impact of both these support dimensions on the use of problem-focused coping strategies has not been examined before.

Supervisor support is the degree to which a supervisor cares for an employee's well-being and offers work-related assistance to facilitate his or her job performance (Kottke & Sharafinski, 1988; Susskind et al., 2003). Team or coworker support, instead, refers to the extent to which colleagues provide work-related assistance to one another (Susskind et al., 2003). We predict that supervisor and team support are directed at supporting a frontline employee's efforts to fulfill his or her role requirements autonomously (action coping) while simultaneously preventing this employee from seeking the help from others (instrumental support seeking). However, whereas supervisor support is most likely driven by motivating employees to autonomously fulfill the organization's operational goals, team support lacks hierarchical differences and thus tends to be more informal (Liaw et al., 2010; Susskind et al., 2003; Tian, Song, Kwan, & Li, 2018). Accordingly, a team supporter might want to avoid additional tasks being assigned to him/herself that an instrumental support seeking coworker would hand over.

H₅: (a) Supervisor support and (b) team support promote frontline employees' tendency to use action coping.

H₆: (a) Supervisor support and (b) team support lessen frontline employees' tendency to use instrumental support seeking.

Methodology

Study context

We chose retail banking as the context for our study, interviewing retail banking counselors from branches of six banks in three countries (France, Germany, and Poland) to test the hypothesized relationships. Retail banking represents an appropriate setting for this research for two main reasons: First, retail banking employees perform typical frontline functions in boundary-spanning positions (Bettencourt & Brown, 2003), and the frontline employees, managers, and customers are all involved in the service process to a high degree (Chebat & Kollias, 2000; Morales Mediano & Ruiz-Alba, 2018). Banking service provision thus potentially generates substantial role ambiguity (Bettencourt & Brown, 2003; Chebat & Kollias, 2000; Rigopoulou, Theodosiou, Katsikea, & Perdakis, 2012). In the context of growing digitalization and the increasing use of online banking tools, Ernst & Young (EY) states that 'banks will need an adaptable, "intrapreneurial" workforce, with the diversity of thoughts that promotes innovation' to meet the individualized expectations of the millennial generation (EY, 2016, p. 7). In addition, within the banking industry, the last few decades have seen a substantial decline in regulations and formalized procedures (Black & Strahan, 2001), which increasingly gives the frontline employees decision-making responsibilities. This new setting emphasizes experiences of role ambiguity for retail banking employees.

Second, banking services tend to be comparable across countries, due to their internationality and high standardization (Malhotra, Ulgado, Agarwal, Shainesh, & Wu, 2005; Schumann et al., 2010). We selected different branches in both urban and rural areas and in economically well-off and struggling neighborhoods. Thus, our study purposefully included three countries, different regional areas within each country, various organizational climates (different banks) and varying performance levels (different branches). Further, we confirmed that all interrogated bank employees had similar responsibilities, which were account management and investment consulting.

Sample and sampling procedure

Before collecting the data with pencil-and-paper questionnaires, we pretested the items. We asked 92 branch managers of the six banks to inform their employees in advance about the survey, after which we provided instructions on how to complete the questionnaires in each branch, providing supportive video clips with instructions in several languages. The employees answered the survey anonymously in the bank, and their participation was voluntary, without any incentive. Thus, we collected data from 390 frontline banking counselors, 43% from Poland, 33% from Germany, and 24% from France. Of the respondents 70% were female and 30% were male. This distribution is fairly representative for European countries, as the Eurofound reports an average share of about 65% of female retail bank employees in the European Union (Eurofound, 2017). The employees' age ranged from 20 to 63 years ($M = 37.18$, $SD = 9.73$), and regarding education had primarily

graduated with a university (55%) or high school (44%) degree. On average, they had worked about 13 years for their current employer ($M = 152.95$, $SD = 122.84$ – number of months). Of the total number of employees 94% were employed full-time. They all worked in direct contact with customers and received their job instructions from a manager.

Measures

We measured the two coping strategies with items developed by Duhachek (2005). We used four items for action coping and three items for instrumental support seeking. Duhachek's (2005) scale was developed in relation to consumer stress, but he had taken the items from other settings, including occupational stress research (Carver et al., 1989; Lazarus & Folkman, 1984), and argues for the applicability of the scale to various settings, which supports us using them in our study. Respondents rated the items on 7-point scales, ranging from 'never' to 'always'.

The four role ambiguity items came from a questionnaire developed by Rizzo et al. (1970) and have often been used in studies examining the role ambiguity of frontline employees, as they are generally deemed appropriate for such purposes (Bettencourt & Brown, 2003; Zablah et al., 2012). For role ambiguity, the 7-point scales ranged from 'totally disagree' to 'totally agree'.

To examine what drives coping, we measured conscientiousness and neuroticism with three items each from the HEXACO personality inventory – revised (PI-R) (Lee & Ashton, 2016). This personality inventory applies well in workplace contexts (Bourdage, Wiltshire, & Lee, 2015). Participants rated their personality traits on 7-point scales ranging from 'totally disagree' to 'totally agree'.

Finally, we included four items from Rhoades, Eisenberger, and Armeli (2001) to measure supervisor support in the questionnaire. These items have been validated in several studies in organizational contexts. We measured team support with one item from Lievens, Conway, and de Corte (2008). As Rossiter (2002) argues, the use of single-item measures is appropriate for simple, unambiguous constructs that can easily be judged by all raters. Also, prior research argues that surveys should be as short as possible to minimize the risk of participant defection from field studies (Schumann, von Wangenheim, & Groene, 2014). Both the supervisor and team support items were assessed on 7-point scales ranging from 'totally disagree' to 'totally agree'.

Because our study took place in three different countries, we translated all items from English into French, German, and Polish, using the back-translation method recommended by Brislin (1970) to ensure accuracy. For the conscientiousness and neuroticism items, HEXACO PI-R is already available in French, German, and Polish (Lee & Ashton, 2016), so in those cases, we used the existing translations. Table 1 lists all the items used in the study.

Analysis and results

Reliability tests

We conducted several tests to confirm the reliability and validity of our data. The results of a confirmatory factor analysis show support for the assumption of reliability and for

convergent and discriminant validity, in that the measurement model with factor structure indicates reasonable fit ($\chi^2 = 429.90$, $df = 189$, $\chi^2/df = 2.27$, confirmatory fit index (CFI) = .95, normed fit index (NFI) = .91, and root mean squared error of approximation (RMSEA) = .06). The Cronbach's α , factor reliability, and average variance extracted (AVE) values exceed their recommended levels (Bagozzi & Yi, 1988; Fornell & Larcker, 1981; Nunnally, 1978) with the exception of two minor deviations of conscientiousness (Cronbach's $\alpha = .69$; AVE = .46). All factors fulfill Fornell and Larcker's (1981) discriminant validity criterion; the square root of the AVE of every factor is higher than its highest interrelation with any other factor (Table 2).

Common method variance

This study could suffer from common method variance, because we measured the dependent and independent variables at the same point in time, using self-assessments by the same respondents (Podsakoff, MacKenzie, Lee, & Podsakoff, 2003). To minimize the risk of common method bias (Podsakoff et al., 2003), we included items with different anchors in our questionnaire. We also asked all participants to answer the questions as spontaneously and honestly as possible, and we assured them that there were no wrong answers. Finally, we guaranteed that all data would be treated anonymously and confidentially. After collecting the data, we controlled for common method variance empirically, by adding a common method factor to the measurement model with the factor structure from the confirmatory factor analysis that was constrained to load equally on all observed variables. Next, we squared the value of this factor loading to get the common method variance, which was .07. The model fit was worse than that for the initial model ($\chi^2 = 503.24$, $df = 194$, $\chi^2/df = 2.59$, CFI = .93, NFI = .90, RMSEA = .06), indicating that common variance is negligible in our study.

Table 1. Measurement items.

Name (Abbr.) and Source	Items
Action coping (AC) (Duhachek, 2005)	Concentrate on ways the problem could be solved. Try to make a plan of action. Generate potential solutions. Think about the best way to handle things.
Instrumental support seeking (ISS) (Duhachek, 2005)	Ask friends/colleagues with similar experiences what they did. Try to get advice from someone about what to do. Have a friend assist me in fixing the problem.
Role ambiguity (RA) (Rizzo et al., 1970)	I feel certain about how much authority I have. R I know what my responsibilities are. R I know exactly what is expected of me. R
Conscientiousness (CON) (Lee & Ashton, 2016)	Explanation is clear of what has to be done. R I check my work repeatedly to find any mistakes. I always try to be accurate in my work, even at the expense of time. People often call me a perfectionist.
Neuroticism (NEU) (Lee & Ashton, 2016)	I feel like crying when I see other people crying. When someone I know well is unhappy, I can almost feel that person's pain myself. I feel strong emotions when someone close to me is going away for a long time.
Supervisor support (SUS) (Rhoades et al., 2001)	My supervisor cares about my opinions. My supervisor really cares about my well-being. My supervisor strongly considers my goals and values. Help is available from my supervisor when I have a problem.
Team support (TS) (Lievens et al., 2008)	Employees work constructively together in teams and help each other.

Notes. **R** = reversed-coded items, inverted before the analyses.

Table 2. Descriptive statistics, intercorrelations, validity, and reliabilities.

	<i>M</i>	<i>SD</i>	a.	b.	c.	d.	e.	f.	g.
a. AC	6.11	0.72	.78						
b. ISS	4.11	1.55	.17**	.81					
c. RA	1.84	1.05	-.40***	.02	.85				
d. CON	5.12	1.25	.45***	.21***	-.33***	.68			
e. NEU	4.69	1.48	.16**	.37***	-.08	.36***	.74		
f. SUS	5.33	1.47	.15**	.04	-.28***	.09	-.05	.88	
g. TS	5.05	1.54	.17**	.05	-.25***	.25***	.04	.38***	–
AVE			.60	.65	.73	.46	.54	.78	–
FR			.86	.85	.91	.71	.78	.93	–
<i>α</i>			.85	.85	.91	.69	.76	.93	–

Notes. AC = action coping, ISS = instrumental support seeking, RA = role ambiguity, CON = conscientiousness, NEU = neuroticism, SUS = supervisor support, TS = team support; AVE = average variance extracted, FR = factor reliability, and α = Cronbach's α . Numbers on the diagonal in italics show the square root of the AVE; because team support was measured by a single item, we calculated no AVE-, FR- and α -values for this factor.

*** $p < .001$, ** $p < .01$.

Test for measurement invariance

Because this study was executed in three different countries, we tested all the scales for measurement invariance across the three countries, according to the procedure recommended by Steenkamp and Baumgartner (1998). We began by testing for configural invariance, using the measurement model with the factor structure from the confirmatory factor analysis, and we split the data into three groups (i.e. France, Germany, and Poland). Thus, we could estimate the model on the country level. The results support our prediction of configural invariance, with appropriate model fit ($\chi^2 = 854.76$, $df = 522$, $\chi^2/df = 1.64$, CFI = .93, Tucker-Lewis index (TLI) = .91, RMSEA = .04). All standardized factor loadings are significant across the three countries, and nearly all of them are above the recommended level of .50 (van Birmelen, de Ruyter, de Jong, & Wetzels, 2002), with the exception of one item in the German sample (i.e. .41 for one conscientiousness item). This evidence indicates that our data are configurally invariant. We tested next for metric invariance by constraining all the factor loadings to be equal across the three countries (Steenkamp & Baumgartner, 1998). The model fit of the constrained model does not indicate full metric invariance. Following Steenkamp and Baumgartner (1998), we then tested instead for partial metric invariance, by comparing the completely constrained model to models in which one factor loading was no longer constrained to be equal across the three countries. The results of these comparisons reveal full metric invariance of three scales (action coping, conscientiousness, and neuroticism) and partial metric invariance of the remaining scales (instrumental support seeking, role ambiguity, and supervisor support). After identifying the partial metric invariant scales, we established a partial metric invariant model that shows reasonable fit ($\chi^2 = 924.71$, $df = 530$, $\chi^2/df = 1.74$, CFI = .91, TLI = .90, RMSEA = .04). Having confirmed the partial metric invariance of our data, we did not proceed further to test for scalar invariance, because our hypotheses tests did not include comparisons of mean values (Steenkamp & Baumgartner, 1998).

Hypotheses tests

Test of direct effects

To test the hypothesized model, we used structural equation modeling using maximum likelihood with all possible direct effects included. Hence, we estimated the hypothesized

direct effects and the direct effects of the coping resources on role ambiguity. We additionally controlled for participants' gender, age, tenure, and country of origin. In general, the model shows reasonable fit ($\chi^2 = 645.15$, $df = 265$, $\chi^2/df = 2.43$, $CFI = .93$, $RMSEA = .06$). In support of H_1 , action coping reduces perceptions of role ambiguity significantly ($\beta = -.26$, $p < .001$). In support of H_2 , we find a significant positive effect of instrumental support seeking on role ambiguity ($\beta = .14$, $p < .01$). The results support H_{3a} but not H_{3b} , in that conscientiousness has a significant positive effect on the tendency to use action coping ($\beta = .40$, $p < .001$), but no significant negative effect on instrumental support seeking ($\beta = .08$, $p = .29$). We find support for H_{4b} but not H_{4a} , because neuroticism has a significant positive effect on instrumental support seeking ($\beta = .32$, $p < .001$), but not on action coping ($\beta = -.05$, $p = .49$). In support of H_{5a} but not H_{5b} , supervisor support ($\beta = .14$, $p = .01$) but not team support ($\beta = .02$, $p = .71$) promotes a tendency to use action coping. Finally, we must reject H_{6a} and H_{6b} , because neither supervisor support ($\beta = .07$, $p = .25$) nor team support ($\beta = -.01$, $p = .91$) have significant effects on instrumental support seeking.

Test of mediating effects

To test the indirect, direct, and total effects of all four coping resources on role ambiguity (over action coping and instrumental support seeking), we adopted Preacher, Rucker, and Hayes's (2007) bootstrap method, as recommended for mediation analyses. The indirect effect of conscientiousness on role ambiguity is negative and significant ($\beta = -.09$, $p < .01$), as are the direct ($\beta = -.17$, $p = .04$) and total ($\beta = -.26$, $p < .01$) effects. We can classify the indirect effect as a complementary mediation (Zhao, Lynch, & Chen, 2010). The indirect effect of neuroticism on role ambiguity is positive and significant ($\beta = .06$, $p = .02$), while the direct ($\beta = -.02$, $p = .80$) and total ($\beta = .04$, $p = .63$) effects are not significant, signaling indirect-only mediation (Zhao et al., 2010). Regarding supervisor support, we do not find a significant indirect effect on role ambiguity ($\beta = -.03$, $p = .12$), but significant and negative direct and total effects (direct $\beta = -.21$, $p < .01$; total $\beta = -.24$, $p < .01$). That is, it represents a direct-only non-mediation (Zhao et al., 2010). Last, the indirect, direct, and total effect of team support on role ambiguity are not significant (indirect $\beta = -.01$, $p = .70$; direct $\beta = -.11$, $p = .12$; total $\beta = -.12$, $p = .11$) – a no-effect non-mediation (Zhao et al., 2010).

Test of interaction effects

Carver and Connor-Smith (2010) propose that coping resources such as social support and personality traits might interact with each other. Such interactions should lead to a strengthening or weakening of coping resources' effects on the coping strategies in the already proposed directions. Such potential interactions have not been examined yet (Carver & Connor-Smith, 2010). Hence, we tested for potential interactions among coping resources according to the procedure for moderations in structural equation models recommended by Marsh, Wen, and Hau (2004) and Wu, Wen, Marsh, and Hau (2013). Neuroticism weakens the positive effect of supervisor support on action coping ($\beta = -.14$, $p = .02$), while team support strengthens this positive effect ($\beta = .19$, $p < .001$).

Role ambiguity's effects on customer perceptions

Due to lower job satisfaction and job performance, role ambiguity, ultimately, can lead to a decline of customers' positive word of mouth and trust. However, a direct effect of frontline employees' perceived role ambiguity on customers' positive word of mouth and trust has to date not been investigated. We examine this relation in an additional analysis to underline the importance of sufficient role ambiguity self-management by frontline employees. Parallel to the retail banking employee survey, we, additionally, interviewed 1,318 customers associated with 343 of the 390 employees, using pencil-and-paper-questionnaires. Customers were contacted by the employee with whom they did business, and who received both surveys, their own and the one intended for their customers. The surveys were packaged together and distributed to employees by their supervisors. After collecting the completed surveys, we could match customer and employee surveys by anonymous codes that were pre-printed on the questionnaires and administered by a third party agency. The customer surveys contained four items to measure customers' positive word of mouth, taken from Bove, Pervan, Beatty, and Shiu (2009), using 7-point scales ranging from 'totally disagree' to 'totally agree', regarding statements such as 'I encourage my friends and relatives to go to my bank' ($M = 4.81$, $SD = 1.48$, Cronbach's $\alpha = .88$). We measured customers' trust in the bank with one item ('Overall I trust my bank ...') adapted from Schumann et al. (2010) on a 10-point scale ranging from 'not at all' to 'completely' ($M = 5.64$, $SD = 1.23$). Results of hierarchical linear regression modeling estimated with the restricted maximum likelihood procedure show that frontline employees' perceived role ambiguity (level 2) significantly affects both customers' positive word of mouth ($b = -.12$, $p = .02$) and trust ($b = -.11$, $p = .01$ – both level 1) in a negative way. In both models we controlled for employees' and customers' gender, age, and country of origin, as well as for employees' tenure.

Discussion

Review of empirical findings and research implications

The results of our study contribute to service research, and especially to role stress and coping research in four important ways. First, in boundary-spanning settings, only action coping reduces role ambiguity of frontline employees. Instrumental support seeking is not effective for lowering experienced role ambiguity; this finding extends and specifies prior research that has examined the dimension as one factor, i.e. as problem-focused coping (Boyd et al., 2009; Koeske, Kirk, & Koeske, 1993; Lewin & Sager, 2008; Srivastava & Tang, 2015). The exclusive effect of instrumental support seeking on frontline employees' role ambiguity has not been examined. Our finding is novel in its indication that instrumental support seeking has an enhancing effect on role ambiguity. Boundary spanners who continuously tell others about lack of clarity on their tasks seem to intensify feelings of ambiguity, by concentrating on it without actually solving the problem. This finding affirms Strizhakova et al.'s (2012) evidence of a similar effect for support seekers in a consumer context. Overall, consulting others in a boundary-spanning context to seek solutions to problems, seems even to be counterproductive. Thus, our findings reveal that future studies should examine the two problem-focused coping strategies separately, as they can have opposite effects.

Second, this study offers an initial model of coping resources that can help frontline employees engage in effective coping. Conscientiousness and supervisor support are important drivers of effective action coping, while neuroticism triggers the use of instrumental support seeking. Our findings extend conceptual evidence by specifying concrete, effective, internal and external coping resources (Goolsby, 1992; Porter et al., 2003). Our results, however, only partially confirm findings from research of coping in a private context (Carver & Connor-Smith, 2010; Connor-Smith & Flachsbart, 2007). That is, we do not find a negative effect of neuroticism on action coping or conscientiousness on instrumental support seeking. These findings result from the professional context in which personality traits may work differently to the way they do in private settings (O'Brien & DeLongis, 1996). The impact of personality traits on coping behavior differs across diverse settings, because the domain of a stressor largely determines how personality traits effect the use of coping strategies (Carver & Connor-Smith, 2010; Lee-Baggley, Preece, & DeLongis, 2005). For example, O'Brien and DeLongis (1996) argue that the effect of personality traits on coping is moderated by situational factors such as work contexts.

Third, our findings contribute to research on the moderating effects of personality traits and how they affect the choice of coping strategies, in that such interactions are largely unexplored (Carver & Connor-Smith, 2010). Even if neuroticism has no direct negative effect on action coping, it is an important moderating factor that inhibits the positive effect of supervisor support on action coping. Our results show, for the first time, that the positive effect of supervisor support depends on the personality of a frontline employee. Although prior research has demonstrated an effect of supervisor support on the coping strategies conceptualized by Lazarus and Folkman (1984) (Lewin & Sager, 2008), a moderating effect of personality on this kind of social support in service settings, has not been considered. With our study, we identify an important contingency factor for the use of coping resources in a boundary-spanning context.

Fourth, in contrast to our expectations, there is a crucial difference between supervisor support and team support. Supervisors directly support employees' efforts to reach organizational goals and fulfill role requirements (i.e. action coping). Coworkers' support, however, is only effective in supporting the use of action coping when supervisor support is already provided, i.e. it strengthens this positive effect. This finding confirms and extends research by Susskind et al. (2003) and Tian et al. (2018), who note a strong relation between supervisor support and organizational goals. In the case of coping, team support seems to be more generic and only assist supervisor support that is really aimed at pushing the frontline employee to autonomously mitigate ambiguous situations, i.e. action coping. The different effects of supervisor and team support also confirm prior assertions based on social exchange theory (Blau, 1964), namely that social support in service settings comes from multiple, unequally operating sources (Susskind et al., 2003).

Managerial implications

From a managerial perspective, we offer three distinct suggestions. First, supervisor support in its current state should be favored over team support, and therefore implemented and/or trained in service firms. Such training could include explicit sessions in which supervisors learn how to communicate organizational goals to their employees. It

should also focus on how the use of action coping can be transferred from a supervisor to employees through distinct support processes. Thus, managers should learn to advise their employees, to ensure they implement the use of action coping when they are confronted with stressors.

Second, team support only has a positive effect when supervisor support is already provided, therefore frontline employees should be sensitized to the best ways of supporting their colleagues. Service firms should implement frontline employee training sessions to help them learn to integrate organizational goals in their behavior toward colleagues. Hence, they should direct their support to be more specific. The training of frontline employees thus could include sessions that discuss action coping solutions for routine problems.

Third, in their hiring procedures, service firms should consider including a personality trait profile to specifically assess potential employees' conscientiousness and neuroticism. Our results indicate the need to consider the entire personality profile, instead of focusing on single personality traits. Accordingly, recruitment should focus on both highly conscientious and simultaneously less neurotic candidates. Candidates with such a personality profile should be identified and be given preference in hiring.

Limitations and further research directions

This study has some limitations, which point to directions for further research. First, self-assessments of applied coping strategies involve a risk of social desirability bias. Therefore further studies could include third party ratings of employees' coping strategies. Still, as instrumental support seeking shows a relatively high mean value, frontline employees in this study seemingly admitted to seeking help at work, which points to realistic self-assessment. Second, following prior findings by Carver and Connor-Smith (2010) and Connor-Smith and Flachsbart (2007), we only tested the effects of two personality traits. The three other Big Five personality traits – openness to experience, extraversion, and agreeableness – could possibly have effects on the use of certain coping strategies too. Hence, continued research should examine the effects of all the Big Five personality traits on coping. Finally, we distinguished the two problem-focused coping strategies identified by Duhachek (2005). Because our model is a first attempt at analyzing both drivers and outcomes of problem-focused coping in a boundary-spanning context that are generally presumed to be effective, we consider this focus adequate. However, additional studies could analyze the sub-dimensions of emotion-focused coping, along with their drivers and outcomes, in boundary-spanning contexts.

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